

# Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

## US, El Salvador officials stay united

Top Trump advisers, Bukele say Maryland man will not return

By Seung Min Kim and Marcos Alemán  
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump's top advisers and Nayib Bukele, the president of El Salvador, said Monday that they

have no basis for the small Central American nation to return a Maryland man who was wrongly deported there last month. Bukele called the idea "preposterous" even though the U.S. Supreme Court has called on the administration to "facilitate" Kilmar Abrego Garcia's return.

Trump administration officials emphasized that Abrego Garcia, who was sent to a notorious gang prison in El Salvador, was a citi-

zen of that country and that the U.S. has no say in his future. And Bukele, who has been a vital partner for the Trump administration in its deportation efforts, said "of course" he would not release him back to U.S. soil.

"The question is preposterous. How can I smuggle a terrorist into the United States?" Bukele, seated alongside Trump, told reporters in the Oval Office. "I don't have the power to return him to the United

States."

Should El Salvador want to return Abrego Garcia, the U.S. would "facilitate it, meaning provide a plane," Attorney General Pam Bondi said.

But "first and foremost, he was illegally in our country, and he had been illegally in our country," she said. "That's up to El Salvador if they want to return him. That's not up to us."

The refusal of both countries to

allow the return of Abrego Garcia, who had an immigration court order preventing his deportation over fears of gang persecution, is intensifying the battle over the Maryland resident's future. It has also played out in court filings, with repeated refusals from the government to tell a judge what it plans to do, if anything, to repatriate him.

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## Red tape is slowing adoption of solar

Permitting process in Illinois contributes to rising costs, report says

By Nara Schoenberg  
Chicago Tribune

In Illinois, solar installers often face "complex and cumbersome" permitting requirements that can add months — and hundreds of dollars in cost — to the simplest residential roof project, according to a new report from environmentalists and consumer advocates.

In some places, installers reported having to submit applications in person, rather than via email or an online portal.

One installer complained about having to place six calls just to obtain a permit that had already been approved; others said they navigate needlessly complex and drawn-out review processes or face "wacky" formatting requirements.

Among the results: The state is viewed as "a very good market because of all the incentives, but an absolute nightmare to operate in," an Illinois solar installer was quoted as saying. Aurora, Elmhurst and Joliet were among the places where installers reported problems.

The report, released Thursday by Environment Illinois Research & Education Center and the Illinois PIRG Education Fund, calls on the state to streamline the process by adopting instant permitting software — an approach already in place in California and on the way in Maryland.

Instant permitting software checks whether a project is compliant with national and local building codes and can approve a permit within a matter of minutes.

Options include SolarAPP+, which was developed by the Department of Energy's National Renewable Energy Laboratory in collaboration with building and safety experts and is offered free to local governments.

"(Instant permitting) is a pretty easy way to just get more of these small-scale solar projects onto the

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Anna Chlystek, center, plays balloon volleyball with other residents at Encore Village in Schaumburg on April 8. Encore Village, formerly Friendship Village before a Chapter 11 filing in 2023, is among a number of senior living facilities that have experienced financial trouble. **AUDREY RICHARDSON/TRIBUNE**

## Bankruptcies at senior homes costing residents

People have collectively lost millions of dollars in entrance fees at suburban facilities

By Robert McCoppin  
Chicago Tribune

A recent bankruptcy filing by a network of senior living facilities in Illinois and Indiana highlights the financial risk posed to residents who pay large entry fees to continuing care retirement communities, but get limited government protections, senior advocates say.

In February, a Lutheran not-for-profit that operates several long-term care facilities — including Lutheran Home in Arlington Heights — filed for Chapter 11

bankruptcy, seeking to continue operations while shedding debt.

The latest bankruptcy follows a Chapter 11 filing in 2023 by Schaumburg's Friendship Village, now called Encore Village. The Oaks at Bartlett also filed for bankruptcy in 2011 and 2019, went into receivership in 2024 and was sold.

All the facilities continue to serve residents in their homes, but at Encore Village and The Oaks at Bartlett, scores of residents collectively lost millions of dollars in fees they paid to get into the residences.

Officials at The Oaks at Bartlett

and Lutheran Life Communities did not immediately respond to requests for comment. But Encore Village CEO Avi Satt told the Tribune, "Things are going incredibly well at the community."

Encore switched to a rental-only model, without the high entry fees, and plans on investing \$15 million in upgrades and maintenance to the building. The facility has had record growth, with 693 residents in 860 units.

"The community is in a healthy place financially today, and residents have been happy to move on from the previous negative effects

of the bankruptcy," Satt wrote.

But some families are upset about meager refunds. At the former Friendship Village, just \$2 million was set aside to pay entry fee refunds owed to about 100 families.

Richard Anderson, whose father paid a \$261,000 fee in 2021 to enter Friendship Village, where he still lives, was upset about the lack of prior disclosure that the facility was in dire financial straits.

He noted it is a felony to commit financial deception of a senior citi-

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## Jones jurors hear about former senator

State Sen. Emil Jones III may be the one who's on trial for bribery, but the jury deciding his fate heard plenty Monday about one of Jones' former colleagues: deceased state Sen. Martin Sandoval, who had pleaded guilty to federal corruption. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

## Bulls face play-in with slew of injuries

The Bulls might begin the NBA Play-In Tournament without three point guards. Lonzo Ball is not expected to be available. Josh Giddey is questionable. And Tre Jones hasn't been cleared to remove a walking boot. **Chicago Sports**

## CTU approves contract with historic support



Chicago Teachers Union President Stacy Davis Gates arrives Monday before announcing that CTU members voted to ratify a new contract with Chicago Public Schools. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Vote by members avoids strike ahead of fight vs. federal threats

By Nell Salzman  
Chicago Tribune

Members of the Chicago Teachers Union voted to ratify a new contract with Chicago Public Schools, marking the first time in 15 years that the union settled its contract without a strike or a strike vote.

It has been far from easy to get the tentative agreement across the finish line, despite the union's ally, Mayor Brandon Johnson, helping the negotiation process along.

And while CTU President Stacy

Davis Gates celebrated the win Monday morning, she addressed a new ballooning uncertainty facing the district — federal attacks on public education.

At a news conference, Davis Gates said there were "historic levels of support and unity" in the voting process last week and hammered home the union's plans to resist President Donald J. Trump's threat to cut funding for school districts that have diversity, equity and inclusion programs.

"So look out for red T-shirts on your doors this upcoming summer, because we're going to talk to you about how we hold on to a democracy in the world that is moving quickly towards fascism," Davis

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